

(1) Catholic (Or Roman Catholic) Church

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

The Catholic Church, also known as the Roman Catholic Church, is the largest Christian denomination, with more than 1.2 billion members (called catholic) worldwide out of approximately 2 billion (2014 estimates) Christians. The Catholic Church is one of the oldest religious institutions in the world.

~~The Catholic Church claims that it is the true church founded by Jesus Christ through apostle Peter (first bishop) and its bishops are the successors of Christ's apostles and the Pope is the successor to apostle Peter. It is the earliest branch of Christianity in existence today.

~~The Roman Catholic Church is headed by the Bishop of Rome, known as the Pope, who holds supreme power over the Church. Over the course of time it developed a highly sophisticated theology and an elaborate organizational structure.

~~For the first thousand years, Christianity and Catholicism were synonymous. But in 1054CE a formal split known as the Great Schism, also called the East-West Schism, divided the main stream Christianity (universal church) into Roman Catholic (Western-Latin branches) Church with its seat of power in Rome and the Eastern Orthodox (Eastern-Greek branches) Church with its seat of power (first among equal) in Constantinople. Then again the Protestant Reformation of sixteenth century CE split Roman Catholic Church and gave rise to the protestant denominations we see today.

PURPOSE OF LIFE

According to Catechism (summary of Christian teaching) of the Catholic Church : (CCC#1-3)

The life of man - to know and love God.

1- God, infinitely perfect and blessed in himself, in a plan of sheer goodness freely created man to make him share in his own blessed life. For this reason, at every time and in every place, God draws close to man. He calls man to seek him, to know him, to love him with all his strength. He calls together all men, scattered and divided by sin, into the unity of his family, the Church. To accomplish this, when the fullness of time had come, God sent his Son as Redeemer and Saviour. In his Son and through him, he invites men to become, in the Holy Spirit, his adopted children and thus heirs of his blessed life.

2- So that this call should resound throughout the world, Christ sent forth the apostles he had chosen, commissioning them to proclaim the gospel: "Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, to the close of the age." Strengthened by this mission, the apostles "went forth and preached everywhere, while the Lord worked with them and confirmed the message by the signs that attended it.

3- Those who with God's help have welcomed Christ's call and freely responded to it are urged on by love of Christ to proclaim the Good News everywhere in the world. This treasure, received from the apostles, has been faithfully guarded by their successors. All Christ's faithful are called to hand it on from generation to generation, by professing the faith, by living it in fraternal sharing, and by celebrating it in liturgy and prayer.

CONCEPT OF GOD

Catholics believe in a triune God or Holy Trinity. Which teaches the Godhead or God is made up of three divine persons, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. The three divine persons are truly distinct one from another. Essentially believing that the Father is God, the Son is God, and the Holy Spirit is God, and yet there are not three Gods but only one God. They have the same nature, substance, and being.

~~The mystery (truth which we cannot fully understand)of Holy Trinity — one God in three persons, is the central mystery of the Christian faith and of Christian life. In this mystery of Holy Trinity of Persons the Father has no origin, He came from no one, but the Son is begotten of the Father by an eternal generation , and the Holy Spirit comes or proceeds by an eternal procession from the Father and the Son. Yet, in spite of these different relations of origin the three Persons are eternal and equal in every respect.

The Father is God and the first Person of the Holy Trinity. God the Father Almighty is Creator of heaven and earth, and of all that is, seen and unseen. God the Father is all powerful, all knowing, and everywhere. He is sovereign, loving, merciful ,caring and just. Although the term 'God the Father' implies masculine characteristics, God is a pure spirit without any human biological gender. The Father is made of none, neither created nor begotten.

The Son is God and the second Person of the Holy Trinity. Jesus Christ the only Son of 'God the Father'. The Son is of the Father alone, not made nor created but begotten. Jesus the only begotten Son of the Father. Jesus is God, pre-existed before incarnation, coeternal and coequal with the Father.

~~He was sent (descended from heaven)to the world by the Father to become man and save humanity from their sins. He was conceived by virgin Mary by the power of the Holy Spirit. So the human Jesus Christ had only God as His Father, and the Virgin Mary as His Mother. In His human existence Jesus had two nature, He was fully God and fully human.

~~The main reason that Jesus became man was to redeem mankind from original sin (caused by disobedience of Eve and Adam). He suffered and was crucified which paid the ransom for the sins of mankind. This was necessary for the satisfaction of God's justice and the gaining of grace for men.

~~Jesus died and rose (bodily/physical resurrection) from the dead, glorious and immortal, on Easter Sunday, the third day after His death. And after forty days Jesus ascended into heaven in his resurrected glorious body , where He is seated at the right hand of the Father. There Jesus constantly intercedes on our behalf before the Father for those who draw near to God through Him. He will come again in glory to judge the living and the dead.

The Holy Spirit is God and the third Person of the Holy Trinity. The Holy Spirit is also called the Holy Ghost, the Paraclete, the Spirit of Truth, the Spirit of adoption, the Spirit of Christ, the Spirit of the Lord, the Spirit of God and the Spirit of glory. The Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son, not made nor created nor begotten but proceeding. The Holy Spirit though really distinct, as a Person, from the Father and the Son, He is consubstantial and coequal with Them; being God like Them, He possesses with Them one and the same Divine Essence or Nature.

~~The Holy Spirit is at work with the Father and the Son from the beginning to the completion of the plan for humanity's salvation. As promised, Jesus sent Him from the Father on the day of Pentecost to remain continually in the Church (body of believers) to teach and guide believers with all truth.

The first, second and third with regard to the Persons of the Holy Trinity do not mean that one person was before the other or that one is greater than the other; for all the persons of the Trinity are eternal and equal in every respect. These numbers are used to mark the distinction between the persons, and they show the order in which the one proceeded from the other.

According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC), "Now this is the Catholic faith: We worship one God in the Trinity and the Trinity in unity, without either confusing the persons or dividing the substance; for the person of the Father is one, the Son's is another, the Holy Spirit's another; but the

Godhead of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit is one, their glory equal, their majesty coeternal (CCC#266). Inseparable in what they are, the divine persons are also inseparable in what they do. But within the single divine operation each shows forth what is proper to him in the Trinity, especially in the divine missions of the Son's Incarnation and the gift of the Holy Spirit. (CCC#267)

THE CATHOLIC CREEDS (PROFESSIONS OF THE FAITH)

The Creeds also called 'professions of faith' and 'symbols of faith' are summary of the faith that a Christian profess. The two most important creeds used widely by the Roman Catholic Church are 'Apostle's Creed' and 'Nicene Creed'.

Apostle's Creed:

The Apostles' Creed is older of the two and is simple and brief. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC#194), "The Apostles' Creed is so called because it is rightly considered to be a faithful summary of the apostles' faith. It is the ancient baptismal symbol of the Church of Rome. Its great authority arises from this fact: it is "the Creed of the Roman Church, the See of Peter the first of the apostles, to which he brought the common faith".

The English text of the Apostle's Creed: "I believe in God, the Father Almighty, Creator of Heaven and earth; and in Jesus Christ, His only Son Our Lord, Who was conceived by the Holy Spirit, born of the Virgin Mary, suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and was buried. He descended into Hell; the third day He rose again from the dead; He ascended into Heaven, and seated at the right hand of God, the Father almighty; from thence He shall come to judge the living and the dead. I believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy Catholic Church, the communion of saints, the forgiveness of sins, the resurrection of the body and life everlasting. Amen."

Nicene Creed:

The Nicene Creed is longer of the two and contains some additional language explaining Catholic belief in the Trinity. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC #195), "The Niceno-Constantinopolitan or Nicene Creed draws its great authority from the fact that it stems from the first two ecumenical Councils (in 325 and 381). It remains common to all the great Churches of both East and West to this day."

The English text of the Nicene Creed: "I believe in one God, the Father almighty, maker of heaven and earth, of all things visible and invisible. I believe in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Only Begotten Son of God, born of the Father before all ages. God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten, not made, consubstantial with the Father; through him all things were made. For us men and for our salvation he came down from heaven, and by the Holy Spirit was incarnate of the Virgin Mary, and became man. For our sake he was crucified under Pontius Pilate, he suffered death and was buried, and rose again on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures. He ascended into heaven and is seated at the right hand of the Father. He will come again in glory to judge the living and the dead and his kingdom will have no end. I believe in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the giver of life, who proceeds from the Father and the Son, who with the Father and the Son is worshipped and

glorified, who has spoken through the prophets. I believe in one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church. I confess one Baptism for the forgiveness of sins and I look forward to the resurrection of the dead and the life of the world to come. Amen."

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Catholics believe in two sources of religious/sacred information :

- (1) Sacred Scripture (Bible) and
- (2) Sacred Tradition (or Holy Tradition).

Catholics believe that the entire revelation of Jesus Christ is preserved and passed down to successive generations in the above mentioned two different forms and are collectively known as "Deposit of Faith". (For more details CCC# 75,76, 97 @ http://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_INDEX.HTM)

(1) Sacred Scripture (The Holy Bible):

The Holy Bible is composed of a total of 73 books. The first 46 books known as Old Testament and the last 27 books are known as New Testament. Seven out of the 46 books of the old testament are called Deuterocanonical-'second canon' because their status as being part of the Sacred Scripture was settled later in time than the other books.

--"The Sacred Scriptures contain the Word of God and, because they are inspired, they are truly the Word of God"(CCC#135)

-- God is the author of Sacred Scripture because he inspired its human authors; he acts in them and by means of them. He thus gives assurance that their writings teach without error his saving truth.(CCC#136)

-- The unity of the two Testaments proceeds from the unity of God's plan and his Revelation. The Old Testament prepares for the New and the New Testament fulfils the Old; the two shed light on each other; both are true Word of God. (CCC#140)

(2) Sacred Tradition (or Holy Tradition):

Sacred Tradition is Divine instructions and revelations which were made to the Apostles either orally by Jesus Christ or by the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, which were not committed to the inspired writings (Bible), and were transmitted by the Apostles to the Church. (For more details CCC# 81)

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

THE CHURCH

The Church is a divine institution founded by Christ for salvation of the believers. Catholics believe in one, holy, catholic and apostolic Church. The Church is the congregation of all those who profess the faith of Christ, partake of the same Sacraments, and are governed by their lawful pastors under one visible head the pope who is the successor of Apostle Peter, whom Christ appointed to build and lead the church. Jesus Christ as the invisible head of the church, founded the Church to teach, govern, sanctify, and save all men. All Catholics belong to the one true Church, body of Christ, temple of the Holy Spirit, and whoever knows the Church to be the one true Church and remains out of it cannot be saved.

A building or physical structure where Christians gather for worship or religious activities (congregation) is also called a church. All Roman Catholic churches all over the world are parts of the 'Roman Catholic Church' based in Rome headed by Pope (bishop of Rome).

THE POPE

The Pope is the visible head of Roman Catholic Church, the Bishop of Rome, the successor of Apostle Peter and Vicar of Jesus Christ on earth. Pope is also called "the pontiff," "the Holy Father," and "the Vicar of Christ,".

~~As the religious and spiritual leader of the Catholic Church the Pope is infallible when he speaks 'ex cathedra' that is when in the exercise of his office as pastor and teacher of all Christians he defines, by virtue of his supreme Apostolic authority, a doctrine of faith or morals for whole Catholic Church.

~~The Pope is not infallible in everything he says and does, but only in matters of faith and morals for the whole Church as mentioned above. His opinion on any subject is taken with greatest respect on account of his knowledge and authority. Infallibility does not prevent pope from sinning, it only prevents him from teaching falsehood when he speaks ex-cathedra. (For more details CCC# 882,891)

~~He is the symbol of unity and constant assurance to the Catholic believers that they are guided by a shepherd who is the successor of Apostle Peter handpicked by Jesus Christ.

~~Pope is also the head of the administrative affairs of the Catholic Church. He appoints bishops and cardinals to run central and local affairs. After the death or resignation (in very rare cases) of a pope, a new pope is elected by the college of cardinals (this process is known as 'Papal Conclave').

THE CLERGY

The Catholic Church only appoints male and almost all unmarried clergy. The clergy include deacons, priests/presbyters, and bishops. All clergy must be celibate the only exception is given in the case of deacons who do not intend to become priests. The Catholic Church only ordains celibate men to the priesthood. (For more details CCC# 1577,1579)

NUNS, SISTERS, MONKS AND FRIARS

Catholic nuns, sisters and monks are individuals who have totally dedicated their lives to God; taken the vows of poverty, chastity (celibacy) and obedience. These individuals (except ordained monks) are not considered members of the clergy. These individuals are usually members of a particular

religious order and follow the rule of its order, such as the Rule of St. Augustine or Rule of St. Benedict etc.

Catholic nun is a woman who professes the perpetual solemn vows to live a life of poverty, celibacy, and obedience. Nuns live a contemplative, cloistered (or enclosed) or semi-cloistered life of meditation and prayer for the salvation of others, in a monastery. They recite the Liturgy of the Hours or Divine Office in common, and engage in some work within the monastery to help support themselves.

Catholic sister is a woman who professes perpetual simple vows to live a life of poverty, celibacy, and obedience. Sisters live in convent which offer more open access to the outside community and typically live and pray in the convent but work outside in schools, hospitals, or religious institutions. Both nuns and sisters are addressed as 'Sister'.

Catholic monk may be a priest or a deacon who has received the Sacrament of Holy Orders, or a religious brother, who is not ordained. A monk is a member of a community of men, leading a more or less contemplative, cloistered (or enclosed) or semi-cloistered life apart from the world, under the vows of poverty, chastity, and obedience. Monks live in a monastery in prayer, meditation, liturgy and work within the monastery.

Catholic friar is also a member of a community of men, leading a more or less contemplative life under the vows of poverty, chastity, and obedience. Friars live in a friary in prayer, meditation and usually engage in an active ministry of service (like education, health care, or other charitable work) to the outside community. Friars may work in the community and are supported by donations or other charitable support.

MARY

Mary is the mother of Jesus, Son of God the second person of the Holy Trinity. Catholics respect and think very highly of Mary, to them, she “illuminates” the faith in Christ. They believe that Mary's status is below Jesus but above that of the saints and angels.

~~Catholics believe Mary is Theotokos (God-Bearer) and truly the Mother of God. They also believe in the Immaculate Conception of Mary. Which means she was conceived without any stain of original sin in order to be a sinless bearer of God incarnate, Jesus Christ. They also believe in perpetual virginity of Mary. A belief that Mary remained a virgin all her life, before, during and after giving birth to Jesus. They also believe in Assumption of Mary. A doctrine that teaches that after the course of her earthly life, Mary was assumed body and soul into heaven by the power of God.

~~Mary is regarded highly, as she offers many graces and mercy to all who call upon her intercession. Mary is often prayed to by Roman Catholics to intercede on their behalf as in heaven she occupies a special place interceding between God and His people. Catholic devotion and veneration of Mary has grown over time in importance, and is manifested not only in prayer but also in consecration and entrustment to the Virgin Mary, the visual images, statues, poetry and music. (For more details CCC# 966,969)

THE SAINTS

In the Roman Catholic church the term 'Saint' is reserved for those individuals who have led a holy and exemplary life, have entered Heaven upon death, and are considered worthy of greater honor,

emulation, or veneration, who receives official ecclesiastical recognition given by canonization. The Catholic Church only recognizes (after a rigorous due process call canonization) a person of remarkable holiness who lived a life of heroic virtue, assisted by the Church, during their pilgrimage on earth, upon proof of their "holiness" or likeness to God.

~~According to the Church one may not worship a saints but may revere, ask for things and pray to them to intercede for that individual. Catholics consider the intercession of these saints to be effective on account of their closeness to God. (For more details CCC# 956)

~~A patron saint is a saint of a particular cause, profession, or locale, or invoked as a protector against specific illnesses or disasters. Once a person is canonized, the deceased body , images, the remains and personal belongings of the saint are considered holy relics.

THE ANGELS

Catholics believe that angels are pure spirit and had no matter or body. They are personal, immortal, heavenly beings who have intelligence and will and they are of a nature higher than men (in fact all visible creatures). Angels are created beings, superior to men, were created before men and have greater knowledge than men but not omniscient. Angels being pure spirits are more perfect because by their very nature, they are more like God.

~~The Angels worship God and venerate His divine majesty through all eternity. The angels are ever attentive to God and fulfill God's will. Angels never do anything on their own, they only do what God wants and assigns them to do. As an intermediary between God and humanity they often serve as mediators, messengers, guardians, and guides to humanity.

~~Catholics pray to angels for their help, guidance, protection and intercession. Catholics believe that all Christians have a guardian angel to lead, guide, guard them and also offer their prayers, good works and desires to God. Catholics recognize three angels (archangels-considered "princes" of the angels) by name: Michael, Gabriel and Raphael.

~~Traditionally, angels are said to be divided into nine different categories (nine choirs)of angels, with appropriate missions and activities assigned to them. The nine choirs of angels are Seraphim, Cherubim, Thrones, Dominations or Dominions , Virtues, Powers, Principalities, Archangels and Angels. All the angels are not equal in dignity. In the hierarchy the highest are Seraphim and the lowest are Angels.

~~Angels can appear by taking bodies to render themselves visible to people for a time. Art, imagery and illustration of angels help to show certain attributes and to distinguish between different categories of angels.

~~(For more information, CCC#328-336 and also Baltimore Catechism BC#216-228)

THE FALLEN ANGELS (SATAN AND DEMONS)

The Fallen Angels are wicked or rebellious angels those have been cast out of heaven who radically and irrevocably rejected God and His reign. Satan or devil is a fallen angel called Lucifer who was at first a good angel, made by God. The Satan and the other demons (fallen angels)were indeed created naturally good by God, but they became evil by their own doing. The angels that followed Satan in his disobedience and rejection of God are called demons (fallen angels).

~~How did some angels become fallen angels is a bit of mystery to the Christians. But the popular Christian belief (theologian's theory) is that God first created the pure spirits (angels). These pure spirits were created good by nature and with superior knowledge. At this beginning point of their creation they had a free will to choose whether to obey God and do His will or not. That was a moral test in heaven to their path to acquire the Beatific Vision of God. The angels (about three quarter)

who passed the test entered into the blessedness of God and Heaven. The angels (about one quarter) who failed the test through their disobedience, pride and envy fell under the ban of eternal damnation from God hence called fallen angels.

~~Traditionally, Satan is known as Lucifer, meaning light-bearer, before his fall was one of the seraphim, the highest choir of angels who see and adore God directly. Other names for Satan in Sacred Scripture are the Evil One, Beelzebub, the Accuser, the Tempter, the Great Dragon and the Ancient Serpent.

~~Satan as the leader of the demons in many disguise constantly lies, tempts, seduces people to sin in order to try to entice them away from God.

~~(For more information, CCC#391-396 and also Baltimore Catechism BC#226-232)

THE SEVEN SACRAMENTS

Sacraments are rituals and events through which God gives the believers grace. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC #1131), "The sacraments are efficacious signs of grace, instituted by Christ and entrusted to the Church, by which divine life is dispensed to us. the visible rites by which the sacraments are celebrated signify and make present the graces proper to each sacrament. They bear fruit in those who receive them with the required dispositions". Sacraments were instituted by Christ and given to the Church to administer and are necessary for salvation and grace.

~~The seven sacraments of Catholic Church are Baptism, Confirmation (or Chrismation), Eucharist, Penance, Anointing of the Sick, Holy Orders and Matrimony.

Baptism: Baptism is also called "first sacrament" and "The door of the Church". Baptism as the first and basic sacrament of Christian initiation, is necessary for salvation, is the sacrament of regeneration and initiation into the Catholic Church that was instituted by Jesus, who accepted baptism from John the Baptist and after His resurrection also ordered the Apostles to baptize in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

~~Baptism is normally performed by a priest by immersing the candidate in water or pouring or sprinkling water over one's head in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Baptism cleanses one from original sin, annuls all previous sins, gives new birth as a Christian and son of God, incorporates one into the Church and body of Christ which empowers to lead the life of Christ.

~~Baptism can be performed on both adults and infants. Baptism is permanent and cannot be repeated. The Church recognizes validly administered baptism of other Christian denominations.

~~(For more information, CCC#1231-1284 and also Baltimore Catechism BC#620-669)

Confirmation: Confirmation is also called Chrismation because the essential rite of the sacrament is anointing with chrism (an aromatic oil consecrated by a bishop). Confirmation as the second sacrament of Christian initiation, is necessary for the completion of baptismal grace, instituted by Christ and instructed His Apostles in its use, at some time before His ascension into heaven.

~~Confirmation is normally performed during the mass by the bishop, who anoints the forehead of each candidate with chrism in the form of a cross saying "Accipe signaculum doni Spiritus Sancti" ("Be sealed with the Gift of the Holy Spirit"). According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC#1316), "Confirmation perfects Baptismal grace; it is the sacrament which gives the Holy Spirit in order to root us more deeply in the divine filiation, incorporate us more firmly into Christ, strengthen our bond with the Church, associate us more closely with her mission, and help us bear witness to the Christian faith in words accompanied by deeds."

~~Confirmation can be performed on adolescents (when the age of reason has been reached) and adults. One can only receive confirmation only once in a lifetime.

~~(For more information, CCC#1285-1321, and also Baltimore Catechism BC#670-707)

The Eucharist: The Eucharist is also called the Blessed Sacrament, Holy Communion and the Lord's Supper. It is third and last sacrament of Christian initiation which completes initiation of a catholic to the religion. It was instituted by Christ at the Last Supper, the night before He died.

~~In the Eucharist Catholics share in the body and blood of Jesus in the form of the bread (must be wheaten and unleavened) and wine (which must be from grapes) passed out to the congregation. Catholic Church believes that the bread and wine of the Eucharist become the actual body and blood (through a process called Transubstantiation) of Jesus Christ.

~~Only validly ordained priests can preside at the Eucharist and recipients must be free from mortal sin. Roman Catholics are obligated to receive Holy Communion at least once a year (during the Lent-Easter season) and encouraged to take it at mass every Sunday, on feast days and even more frequently if one is able to.

~~(For more information, CCC#1322-1419), and also Baltimore Catechism BC#869-953)

Penance: The Sacrament of Penance is also called sacrament of Conversion, Confession or Reconciliation. It is first of two sacraments of healing. It was instituted by Christ on Easter Sunday when He first appeared to the apostles after his Resurrection, breathing on them, he said: "Receive the Holy Spirit. For those whose sins you forgive, they are forgiven; for those whose sins you retain, they are retained" (John 20:22-23).

~~Through the sacrament of Penance the priest, as the agent of God, forgives sins of the penitent (absolution) committed after Baptism, when the sinner is heartily sorry (repentant/contrite) for them, sincerely confesses (confession) all of them, and is willing to make reparation (penance) and do works of reparation for them.

~~According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC#1495)," Only priests who have received the faculty of absolving from the authority of the Church can forgive sins in the name of Christ."

Catholics who have committed mortal sin are obliged to seek God's forgiveness through this sacrament as soon as possible. Catholic church asks its faithful to confess sins at least once a year and encourages frequent confession.

~~(For more information, CCC#1422-1498)

Matrimony: Matrimony or marriage is one of the Seven Sacraments of the Catholic Church, is a lifelong union between a Catholic man and a woman for procreation, love and mutual support.

~~Catholic marriage cannot be dissolved by any human power. Divorce granted by secular authorities does not break the bond of marriage, and one who makes use of such a divorce to marry again while the former husband or wife is alive, commits a sacrilege and lives in the sin of adultery.

~~The Catholic Church sometimes, for very good reasons, does allow husband and wife to separate and live apart; but that is not dissolving the bond of marriage, or divorce as it is called, for though separated they are still husband and wife, and neither can remarry till the other dies.

~~(For more information, CCC#1601-1666)

Holy Orders: Holy Orders is one of the Seven Sacraments of the Catholic Church by which bishops, priests, and deacons of the Church are ordained and receive the power and grace to perform their sacred duties.

~~The Sacrament of Holy Orders are reserved only for men, following the example set by Christ and His Apostles, who chose only men as their successors and collaborators. Celibacy is required (except in the case of permanent deacons) for all bishops, priests and deacons. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC#1600),"It is bishops who confer the sacrament of Holy Orders in the three degrees."

~~(For more information, CCC#1536-1600)

The Anointing of the Sick: The Anointing of the Sick is one of the Seven Sacraments of the Catholic Church also called Unction . It is used to be known as Extreme Unction or Last Rites. It is second of the two sacraments of healing. This sacrament was instituted by Christ and recommended to the faithful and promulgated by Apostle James the brother of Christ.

~~This Sacrament is administered both to the dying due to old age or sickness and to those who are gravely ill, for the recovery of their health and for spiritual strength.

~~According to Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC#1529-1530), "Each time a Christian falls seriously ill, he may receive the Anointing of the Sick, and also when, after he has received it, the illness worsens. Only priests (presbyters and bishops) can give the sacrament of the Anointing of the Sick, using oil blessed by the bishop, or if necessary by the celebrating presbyter himself."

~~(For more information, CCC#1499-1532)

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

Catholic worship range from regular public worship (formal liturgy) to worship in private and small groups, such as meditation, prayer and study. Rituals and prayers are integral parts of Catholic life, from the sacraments which mark the sacred milestones on life's journey to the smaller rituals of daily devotion.

~~Some of the main forms of worship are observing the sacraments, attending the Catholic Mass, fasting, almsgiving, self-denial, praying the rosary, and observing the sacred days etc.

~~The five forms of prayer revealed in the apostolic and canonical Scriptures are:

- (1) Blessing and Adoration (blessing God and respectful silence in the presence of God).
- (2) Prayer of Petition (asking for forgiveness, the quest for the Kingdom, and every true need).
- (3) Prayer of Intercession (asking for on behalf of others).
- (4) Prayer of Thanksgiving (thanking God for all He has given and done).
- (5) Prayer of Praise (Praise God simply because He is God).

~~The three major expressions or styles of prayer are vocal prayer, meditation, and contemplative prayer.

~~The Catholic Church encourages the faithful to regular prayer: daily prayers, the Liturgy of the Hours, Sunday Eucharist, the feasts of the liturgical year.

~~The Catholic Church teaches that it is an obligation to go to Mass every Sunday and other holy days. Examples of obligatory holy days are Mary- Mother of God (January 1), Christmas (December 25), All Saints Day (November 1) etc.

~~According to Baltimore Catechism prayer is necessary for salvation, and without it no one having the use of reason can be saved (Q#1104).

~~Roman Catholics believe in praying only to God. They also pray to Mary and other saints for their help, guidance, protection and intercession.

~~(For more information, CCC#2623-2649, 2700-2724, 2168-2195), and also BC#1098-1124)

SIN

According to Catechism of the Catholic Church, "Sin is an utterance, a deed, or a desire contrary to the eternal law. It is an offense against God. It rises up against God in a disobedience contrary to the obedience of Christ. Sin is an act contrary to reason. It wounds man's nature and injures human solidarity. The root of all sins lies in man's heart....(1871-1873)".

~~Sin is divided into inherited sin called original sin, and committed sin of individuals called actual sin. Sin (actual sin) is divided into two categories primarily based on degree and effect: mortal (greater) and venial (lesser) sins.

Original sin: Original sin is the sin inherited by all mankind as a result of the first sin committed by Adam (and Eve) in his disobedience of God's command not to eat fruit from the Tree of Knowledge. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church, "By his sin Adam, as the first man, lost the original

holiness and justice he had received from God, not only for himself but for all human beings. Adam and Eve transmitted to their descendants human nature wounded by their own first sin and hence deprived of original holiness and justice; this deprivation is called "original sin". As a result of original sin, human nature is weakened in its powers, subject to ignorance, suffering and the domination of death, and inclined to sin (this inclination is called "concupiscence")."(CCC#416-418)

~~Only Jesus and Mary were not born with original sin.

~~Catholics believe original sin is not a committed sin but contracted sin that everyone is born with. It is not a sin resulting from personal immoral actions, it is a state of the soul that represents the fallen nature that was handed down by the fall of the first parents.

Mortal sin: Mortal sin is a serious offense against the law of God which destroys relationship with God. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church, "For a sin to be mortal, three conditions must together be met: 'Mortal sin is sin whose object is grave matter and which is also committed with full knowledge and deliberate consent.' Grave matter is specified by the Ten Commandments, corresponding to the answer of Jesus to the rich young man: 'Do not kill, Do not commit adultery, Do not steal, Do not bear false witness, Do not defraud, Honor your father and your mother.' The gravity of sins is more or less great: murder is graver than theft. One must also take into account who is wronged: violence against parents is in itself graver than violence against a stranger." (1857-1858).

~~Catholics believe mortal sin causes the loss of charity and the state of grace. If this kind of sin is not redeemed by repentance and God's forgiveness, it will result in eternal death in hell. Examples of such sins are idolatry, fornication, adultery, abortion, contraception, incest etc.

Venial sin: Venial sin is a less serious offense against the law of God which does not destroy relationship with God. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church, "One commits venial sin when, in a less serious matter, he does not observe the standard prescribed by the moral law, or when he disobeys the moral law in a grave matter, but without full knowledge or without complete consent." (1862).

~~Venial sin does not cause loss of state of grace. It simply weakens that relationship with God. Unrepented venial sins can affect the duration spent in Purgatory. Examples of such sins are Impatience, selfishness, minor anger etc.

Forgiveness of Sin: Baptism removes original sin along with other personal sins of an individual. For sins committed after baptism, a different sacrament is needed. It is called the sacrament of penance or confession or reconciliation. Catholics believe an individual should first be penitent for committed sins and then forgiveness is achieved through church ritual (Penance), with the assistance of a priest in confession. Once satisfied the priest will forgive the penitent's sins with the power vested upon him. In certain cases the priest may impose certain acts of reparation (satisfaction) like saying some prayers, or doing charitable works etc.

SALVATION

Catholics believe there are two elements necessary for salvation: faith and works. Catholics believe faith is the beginning, root and foundation of salvation. The Catholic Church teaches that salvation comes through Jesus alone as he is the One mediator between God and man who won the saving grace for all humanity by his perfect sacrifice (crucifixion) on the cross for the sins of humanity. In this process, the first step through baptism, one is cleansed from original and all other sin and thus united with God (sanctified or justified) through Christ. Then with the grace of God one is required to be obedient (works) to His commands to maintain salvation.

~~Catholics believe that salvation can be lost through mortal sin but can be regained through confession and penance.

~~(For more information, CCC#1987-2029, 2700-2724, 2168-2195, and also BC#1098-1124)

ESCHATOLOGY

The catholic eschatology (teachings of the end times or last things) deals with death, particular judgment, heaven, purgatory, hell, end of world and second coming of Jesus, Resurrection of the Dead, general (Last) Judgment, and the New Heaven and New Earth till eternity.

Death: Catholics believe that everyone will die once the appointed time for earthly life is over. They believe at the moment of death, the soul is separated from the body and as a natural consequence body will be left on earth to decompose. But the soul is immortal and never ceases to exist, once created. (For more details CCC# 1013, 1016, 1021)

Particular Judgment: Catholics believe that immediately upon death a particular judgment of each soul takes place by Jesus Christ, based on their faith and works. Based on their faith and works some will be immediately rewarded heaven, some will be rewarded heaven after purification and some will be rewarded with eternal damnation in hell.

Heaven: Catholics believe heaven the final resting place of the blessed, is the state of everlasting life in which one see God face to face, are made like God in glory, and enjoy eternal happiness. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church," Those who die in God's grace and friendship and are perfectly purified live forever with Christ. They are like God for ever, for they "see him as he is," face to face...(CCC#1023). This perfect life with the Most Holy Trinity - this communion of life and love with the Trinity, with the Virgin Mary, the angels and all the blessed - is called "heaven." Heaven is the ultimate end and fulfillment of the deepest human longings, the state of supreme, definitive happiness." (CCC#1024).

~~Entrance into Heaven may be direct (immediate) or through purification in Purgatory. Those Catholics who enter directly (immediately) into heaven are called Saints by the Church.

~~Describing heaven Catechism of the Catholic Church says, "This mystery of blessed communion with God and all who are in Christ is beyond all understanding and description. Scripture speaks of it in images: life, light, peace, wedding feast, wine of the kingdom, the Father's house, the heavenly Jerusalem, paradise: "no eye has seen, nor ear heard, nor the heart of man conceived, what God has prepared for those who love him."(CCC#1027).

Purgatory: Catholics believe Purgatory is the intermediate state of unknown duration for those who die in faith but imperfect due to works (unremitted venial sins). In this temporary state one goes through a course of penal purification, to achieve holiness necessary for the final destination in heaven.

~~While souls are being purified in Purgatory by cleansing fire, the family, friends and faithful on earth can help the souls in Purgatory by their prayers, fasts, alms, deeds; by indulgences, and by having Masses said for them. Souls in purgatory are also being helped by the intercession of the saints.

~~(For more details CCC# 1030-1032)

Hell: Catholics believe hell is the final destination for those who die without faith (non-believers) or with unremitted mortal sin. Upon death after judgment by Christ these souls directly (immediately) enter hell for eternity.

~~According to Catechism of the Catholic Church," Jesus often speaks of "Gehenna" of "the unquenchable fire" reserved for those who to the end of their lives refuse to believe and be converted, where both soul and body can be lost. Jesus solemnly proclaims that he "will send his angels, and they will gather . . . all evil doers, and throw them into the furnace of fire,"and that he will pronounce the condemnation: "Depart from me, you cursed, into the eternal fire!"(CCC#1034).

~~Catholicism teaches no one is predestined to hell. One only enters hell after conscious and willful rejection and turning away from God.

End of time/world and Second Coming of Jesus: Catholics believe that Jesus Christ will come back to earth with his angels to end the current period of human history. This is known as Second Coming of Christ or the Parousia or the Day of the Lord.

~~According to Catechism of the Catholic Church , " Since the Ascension Christ's coming in glory has been imminent, even though "it is not for you to know times or seasons which the Father has fixed by his own authority.". This eschatological coming could be accomplished at any moment, even if both it and the final trial that will precede it are "delayed"(CCC#673).

~~Catholic Church teaches (CCC #674-677) that Christ's second coming will precede some significant events such as the full number of the Gentiles and Jews come into the Church, the spread of the Gospel to the whole world, and the final trial of the supreme religious deception of the Antichrist.

~~Catholics do not believe in the literal rule of 1000 years (Millennialism) by Jesus or Rapture in popular conventional understanding of certain Christian denominations. Instead Catholics believe (see CCC#668-669)that Jesus already reigns in eternity and that in this world His reign, established as a seed, is found already in the Church.

Resurrection of the Dead: Catholics like all Christians believe (see CCC#998) in the resurrection of all dead men, women and children. They believe that upon Christ's second coming to earth, he will physically raise all those who have died, giving them back the bodies they lost at death thus uniting body and soul. Everyone will rise from the dead in their own, entire, and in immortal bodies. The bodies of the faithful will be transformed into the pattern of risen Christ: glorified, spiritualized bodies. And the bodies of the wicked (damned) will have the condition necessary for suffering the eternal punishment of hell.

General (Last) Judgment: At the end of time, at Christ's second coming everyone (righteous and wicked) will be resurrected for the General (also called Last or Final) Judgment. Everyone will be gathered in front of Christ the Judge. In the general judgment things will appear as they really are, all actions of an individual: good or evil, visible, hidden or obscure will be laid out before everyone to see.

~~The righteous are sent to heaven (eternal life) forever united with God and wicked are sent to hell (eternal punishment) are forever separated from God.

~~(For more details CCC# 1038-1041)

~~The New Heaven and New Earth till eternity: Catholics believe after the universal judgment the universe will be mysteriously renewed, which will transform humanity and the world to its original state which is called the New Heaven and New Earth (see CCC#1042-1043, 1047).

~~According to Catechism of the Catholic Church," In this new universe, the heavenly Jerusalem, God will have his dwelling among men. "He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning nor crying nor pain any more, for the former things have passed away." For man, this consummation will be the final realization of the unity of the human race, which God willed from creation and of which the pilgrim Church has been "in the nature of sacrament." Those who are united with Christ will form the community of the redeemed, "the holy city" of God, "the Bride, the wife of the Lamb."..... The beatific vision, in which God opens himself in an inexhaustible way to the elect, will be the ever-flowing well-spring of happiness, peace, and mutual communion."(CCC#1044-1045).

~~No one knows exactly when and how this transformation will take place. (more details CCC#1018)

INDULGENCE

According to the teaching of the Catholic Church an indulgence is a remission or reduction of the temporal punishment due to sin, the guilt of which has been forgiven.

~~Catholic Church teaches that there are two punishments for sin; one is called eternal (only for mortal sin) and is inflicted in hell, and the other is called temporal (for both mortal and venial) and is inflicted in this world or in purgatory. The sacrament of penance remits the eternal and may remit only part of the temporal punishment. To remit the remaining temporal sin one must do certain prescribed penances such as praying, fasting, almsgiving, works of mercy etc. Indulgences are a help towards achieving this remission of temporal punishment. An indulgence simply makes penance (work of reparation) lighter, so that one may more easily satisfy for his sins and escape the temporal punishments he deserves.

~~An indulgence is not the purchase of a pardon which secures the buyer's salvation or releases the soul of another from Purgatory. An indulgence is also not a permit to commit sin, a pardon of future sin or a guarantee of salvation

~~Indulgences are of two kinds: partial and plenary. A partial indulgence removes part of the temporal punishment and a plenary indulgence removes all temporal punishment up to that point. According to Baltimore Catechism for the gaining of Plenary Indulgences one is generally required to go to confession and Holy Communion and pray for the intention of the Pope (BC#861).

~~Only the Pope has the power to grant Indulgences for the whole Church. The bishops have power to grant partial Indulgences in their own diocese. Cardinals and some others, by the special permission of the Pope, can also grant certain Indulgences.

~~(For more information, CCC#1471-1479 and also BC#839-868).

STATUES AND IMAGES

Catholics believe God did not forbid the religious usage of statues, images and icons. They believe God forbade the worship of statues, images and icons.

~~They believe statues, images and icons are all reminders of God's Three Divine Persons or Mary or the saint it represents. Catholics do not worship these statues, images and icons rather they adore, revere or worship who is represented by these manmade objects.

~~In Catholicism statues, images and icons are used for decoration, teaching tools and ritual objects. These manmade objects aid in meditation, helping to connect believers with Jesus Christ, or with Mary-mother of God or the saints whose lives they admire and seek their intercession.

~~(For more information, CCC#2129-2132 and also BC#1211-1216)

SEXUAL MORALITY

The Catholic Church teaches that moral sexuality is between a man and a woman, within a valid marriage and open to procreation. The Church condemns all sexual acts and unions outside marriage. The church teaches Catholics to stay chaste until marriage. The Church also forbids all unchaste freedom and all immodesty with oneself or others in looks, dress, words, and actions. Catholic Church considers masturbation, fornication, pornography, prostitution, rape, incest, homosexual practices as grievous (mortal) sins.

~~(For more information, CCC#2331-2400 and also BC#1281-1289)

CONTRACEPTION AND CONCEPTION

The Catholic Church strictly prohibits any deliberate, artificial impediment (artificial contraception) to the procreation of new life. The church's position rules out any contraceptive sex, coitus interruptus (withdrawal), oral and anal sex and any other methods which cannot lead to conception. The Catholic Church considers deliberate and artificial contraception as intrinsically evil (mortal sin).

~~The Catholic Church permits using Natural Family Planning (NFP) through which a woman can determine with good (about 95 percent) accuracy when to have sex and not get pregnant.

~~The Catholic Church considers conception through natural sex between husband and wife is the only morally accepted means to have children. Conception outside of normal sexual intercourse such as donation of sperm or ovum, surrogate uterus, artificial insemination, in vitro fertilization and embryo transfer are considered immoral by the Church.

~~(For more information, CCC#2366-2372 and 2373-2379)

ABORTION

The catholic Church forbids all forms of abortion and considers it as murder of an innocent human being who cannot defend himself in any way. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church," Human life must be respected and protected absolutely from the moment of conception. From the first moment of his existence, a human being must be recognized as having the rights of a person - among which is the inviolable right of every innocent being to life.."(CCC#2270)

~~All parties directly involved (aborter, doctors, nurses, encouraging family members etc.) in abortion procedure are considered perpetrators of grave sin (murder) and are excommunicated from the church. According to Catechism of the Catholic Church," Formal cooperation in an abortion constitutes a grave offense. The Church attaches the canonical penalty of excommunication to this crime against human life...."(CCC#2272)

~~If a medical procedure is carried out which is deemed by competent medical professionals to be vital to the survival of the mother which may possibly or definitely will result in an abortion, then this is not a sin provided that the abortion of the child is not an expressly desired result.

~~(For more information, CCC#2270-2275)

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

The Catholic Church does not allow divorce and do not recognize divorce in any form or shape whatsoever. No exception for unchastity, infidelity or adultery. Once properly married as catholic (sacrament of matrimony) it is for life and it is indissoluble.

~~The Catholic church allows annulments which it calls "decree of nullity". A decree of nullity is a declaration – not that the marriage is now dissolved – but after sufficient investigation, that a marriage never existed in the first place.

~~Remarriage is only possible upon death of a spouse or after getting an annulment.

~~Catholics who get remarried after getting a civil divorce (divorce through civil court or state) are considered adulterers and are not allowed to receive communion.

~~(For more information, CCC#2382-2386, 1644-1651)

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

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